tive participant in the rally, or that viral video taunts by cow vigilante Monu Manesar had preceded the event. The violence soon spread to the neighbouring areas of Gurugram, leaving more than seven people dead, several injured and 85 vehicles charred. The VHP has since alleged that it was a "terrorist attack", referring to the fact that the yatra had come under fire from "sophisticated weapons". Counter-claims, too, flew thick and fast. The Haryana police has filed over 40 FIRs and rounded up 150-odd suspects, but VHP leaders such as joint general secretary Surendra Jain kept taunting the BJP-led Khattar government, asking them to bring out the bulldozers. "If they don't have bulldozers, they can get some on loan from neighbouring Uttar Pradesh," said Jain, alluding to Yogi's penchant for that 'extra-judicial' mode of law-keeping, which had famously earned him the moniker 'Bulldozer Baba'. Haryana officials denied any such pressure and called the crackdown a routine drive against encroachments on public land.



CRASH TEST An alleged illegal school building being brought down in Nuh; (inset) a scene from the riots

In the past few years, 'bulldozer justice' has become standard operating procedure in BJP-ruled states. On the pretext of cracking down on crime and mafia dons, or hitting back at rioters, BJP chief ministers have been freely using the bulldozer. The actions became the subject of a number of PILs challenging the "extra-judicial and disproportionate" level of retribution against accused individuals before they were convicted by the courts. Last year, the Supreme Court directed the UP government to refrain from demolitions except in accordance with established law. In response, the state submitted an affidavit in July stating that the demolitions in Kanpur (a mother and daughter died in an eviction drive in February) and Prayagraj (properties belonging to alleged mafia don Atiq Ahmed and his aides were brought down) followed the Uttar Pradesh Urban Planning and Development Act, 1973. In short, the official stance was that the action was not linked to riots but initiated in response to building rule violations. The same plea has been used by the Khattar regime to justify the Nuh demolitions, but now the court has asked for information on whether notices were issued to the owners of the destroyed buildings.

In Madhya Pradesh, Chief Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan had taken up the bulldozer fetish—he deployed the machines against "stone-pelters" after a Ramnavami yatra in Khargone led to Hindu-Muslim violence last year. Since then, Chouhan has been trying to build a 'tough CM' image, knocking down structures in all 52 districts of MP, and saying the "bulldozer campaign" was long overdue against "these organised criminals". It's an election year for MP too, and so, in the first week of July, the bulldozer even turned on the properties of alleged BJP worker Pravesh Shukla in Sidhi district, after a video went viral of him urinating on a tribal. Delhi also witnessed JCBs in action after riots broke out in the Jahangirpuri area in April last year, when a BJP-controlled municipal corporation set them rolling in an "anti-encroachment drive".

BJP REGIMES IN THE STATES HAVE BEEN EAGER TO FOLLOW THE UP MODEL OF 'BULLDOZER BABA' YOGI ADITYANATH

In Uttarakhand, CM Pushkar Singh Dhami is relying on bulldozers to prevent "demographic change" in the state. His target: predominantly Muslim settlements on 11,814 hectares of forest land along the Ganga in Haridwar district and in Nainital and Udham Singh Nagar; along the Gola and Kosi rivers in Dehradun district; and along the Tons, Yamuna,